CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

FURNITURE RESTORER IN THE AI ERA

Landfills are full of disposable furniture — and a growing crowd will pay to save the real stuff instead.

★ **TL;DR — Around $45K median for patient craft work you can start in 1–6 months, no license required. The catch: modest pay and slow work — this is a craft business, not a volume business.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

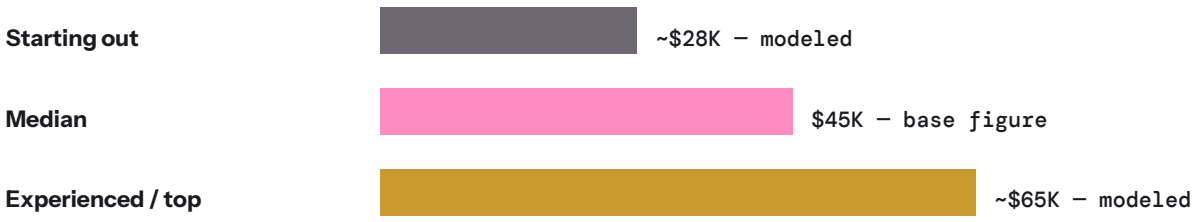
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Why it works: quality old furniture is worth real money, heirs want it saved, and almost nobody local still does this.
- Where it bites: pieces take hours the customer does not see; pricing your time is the whole game.
- The AI angle: AI can appraise a photo and write the listing — stripping, gluing, veneering and color-matching stay stubbornly manual.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Furniture Restorer is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A FURNITURE RESTORER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Assess pieces: structure, veneer, finish, and what is worth saving
- ✓ Strip old finishes, repair joints, replace veneer and re-glue frames
- ✓ Match stains and rebuild finishes by hand, layer by layer
- ✓ Photograph, price and deliver restored pieces or client commissions

Think: a doctor for wooden patients — diagnose first, operate carefully, never rush the recovery.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Photo appraisal tools, marketplace pricing and listing copy are automated now. Identification of makers and eras from a picture is increasingly a phone feature.	The restoration itself is touch work: hide glue behavior, veneer patches, French polish, matching a century-old patina. Slow hands are the entire product.

⚠ **Old finishes can hide lead and nasty chemicals, and stripper fumes are no joke — ventilation and testing are part of the job.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Quiet, focused bench work at your own pace ✓ Every piece is a puzzle with a history ✓ Before-and-after results people genuinely love	✗ Slow work means modest hourly reality ✗ Chemicals, dust and fumes to manage daily ✗ Customers often expect miracles at flea-market prices

Good fit? You are patient, detail-obsessed, and happier reviving old things than producing new ones.
Bad fit? You need speed, volume and a paycheck that grows fast.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — WORKSHOP APPRENTICE	DOOR B — FLIP YOUR OWN PIECES
Antique shops, refinishers and upholstery-adjacent workshops take on bench help. You learn assessment and technique on real pieces with real stakes — the only classroom this craft really has.	Buy damaged quality pieces cheaply, restore them, and sell them finished. The market grades your work brutally and honestly, and your portfolio builds itself — if your skills are already decent.

Smart move: Document every restoration in photos and short videos. Transformation content is free marketing, and mid-century and designer pieces are where the margins hide.

Where you land after: A commission-based restoration bench with a waiting list, possibly paired with dealing in restored pieces.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN TO	BENCH FUNDAMENTAL	FINISH SCHOOL	FIRST COMMISSIONS	BUY, RESTORE,	BUILD THE

STEP 1 — Learn to see furniture

FREE · WEEKS 1-2

- Construction eras, joinery, veneers and finish types
- What makes a piece worth restoring versus firewood

STEP 2 — Bench fundamentals

$100-300 · MONTH 1

- Stripping, gluing, clamping and basic veneer repair on practice pieces
- Set up ventilation and dust control before anything else

STEP 3 — Finish school

MONTHS 1-3

- Stain matching, shellac, lacquer and oil finishes
- Color is where restorations succeed or get spotted

STEP 4 — First commissions

MONTHS 2-4

- Take simple client pieces: re-glue, touch up, revive
- Quote with hours visible — underpricing is the beginner tax

STEP 5 — Buy, restore, sell

MONTHS 3-6

- Source quality damaged pieces and flip them finished
- Track hours against sale price; learn your real rate

STEP 6 — Build the reputation

MONTH 6

- Before/after portfolio and dealer relationships
- Antique dealers feed steady work to restorers they trust

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: learn to tell solid wood, veneer and laminate apart at a glance.
- □ Days 1–30: set up a safe bench; strip and re-glue practice pieces.
- □ Days 31–60: practice finishes and stain matching until repairs disappear.

□ Days 61–90: take first small commissions and one flip piece.

□ Day 90: a working bench with a portfolio — the waiting list is built one piece at a time.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ OLD WOOD. NEW LIFE. SLOW HANDS. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.